

07

The Saemisch System

Fight the f3 center with ...e5, ...c6, and precise counterplay



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

Understand why f3 strengthens e4 but delays development and changes both kings' safety.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 037 | PAGE 4

Decode: The e5 and c6 structure

In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

LESSON 038 | PAGE 8

Play: The e5 and c6 structure

In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

LESSON 039 | PAGE 12

Decode: The g4 space grab

A restraining pawn move must also create a route for the restricted piece.

LESSON 040 | PAGE 16

Play: The g4 space grab

A restraining pawn move must also create a route for the restricted piece.

LESSON 041 | PAGE 20

Decode: The Panno knight route

A retreat earns its tempo by making the opponent's center less stable.

LESSON 042 | PAGE 24

Play: The Panno knight route

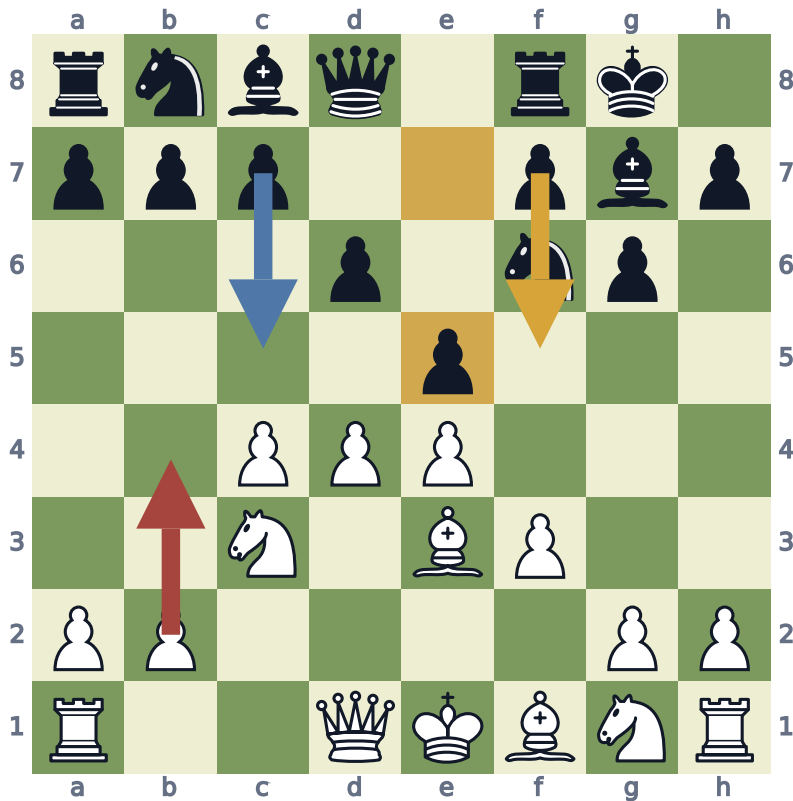
A retreat earns its tempo by making the opponent's center less stable.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

Understand why f3 strengthens e4 but delays development and changes both kings' safety.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The e5 and c6 structure

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling.

DECISION RULE

Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Pressure the center, prepare ...b5 or ...Nh5, and watch the king's destination.

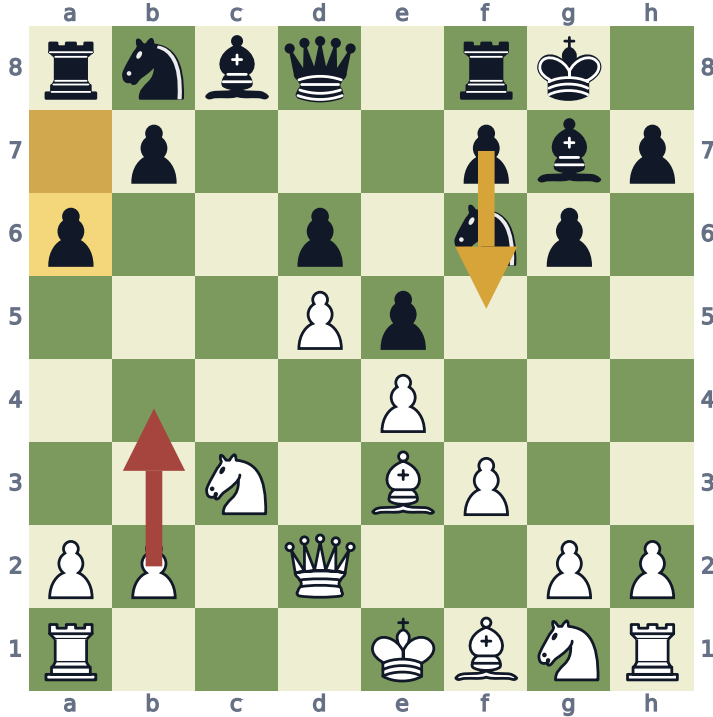
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack.

MEMORY RULE | In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Pressure the center, prepare ...b5 or ...Nh5, and watch the king's destination.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack.

FAILURE MODE

Attacking the queenside automatically can open lines toward your own targets after opposite-side castling.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

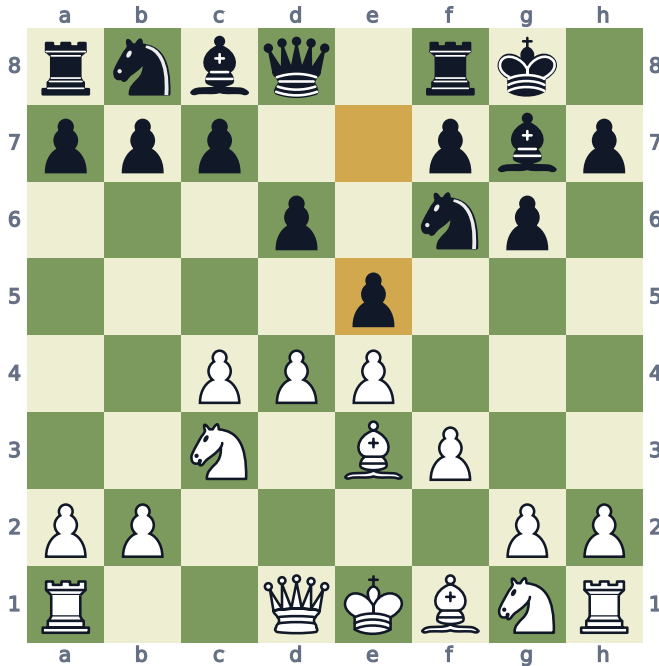
RULE | In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 e5 7. d5 c6 8. Qd2 cxd5 9. cxd5 a6



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king. White's resistance is: White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack. The line fails as a template when: Attacking the queenside automatically can open lines toward your own targets after opposite-side castling.

STORE THIS | In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

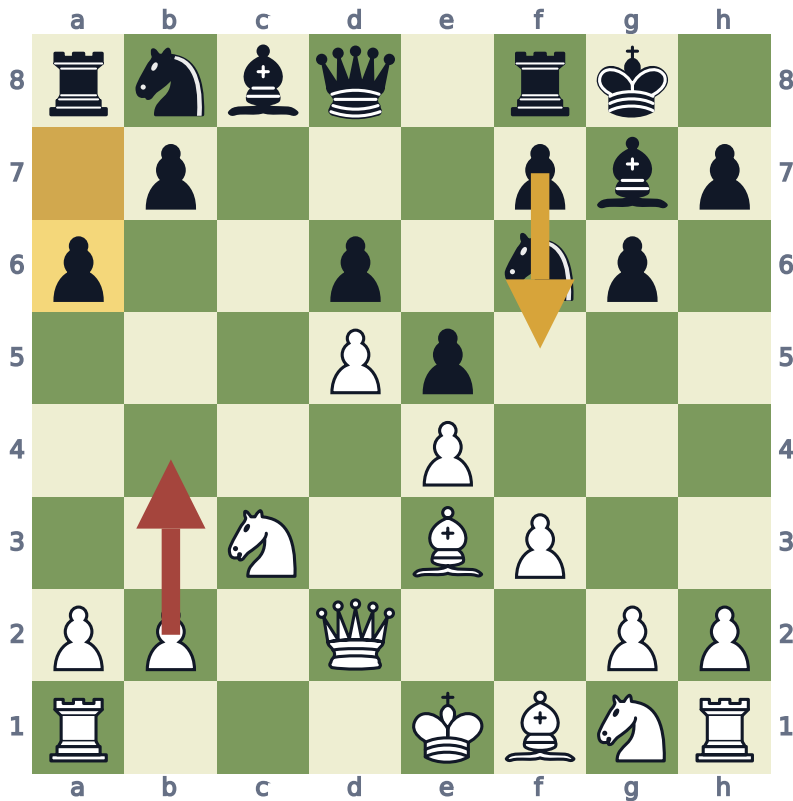
1. Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling. 2. Pressure the center, prepare ...b5 or ...Nh5, and watch the king's destination. 3. White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack. 4. Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king. 5. Attacking the queenside automatically can open lines toward your own targets after opposite-side castling.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The e5 and c6 structure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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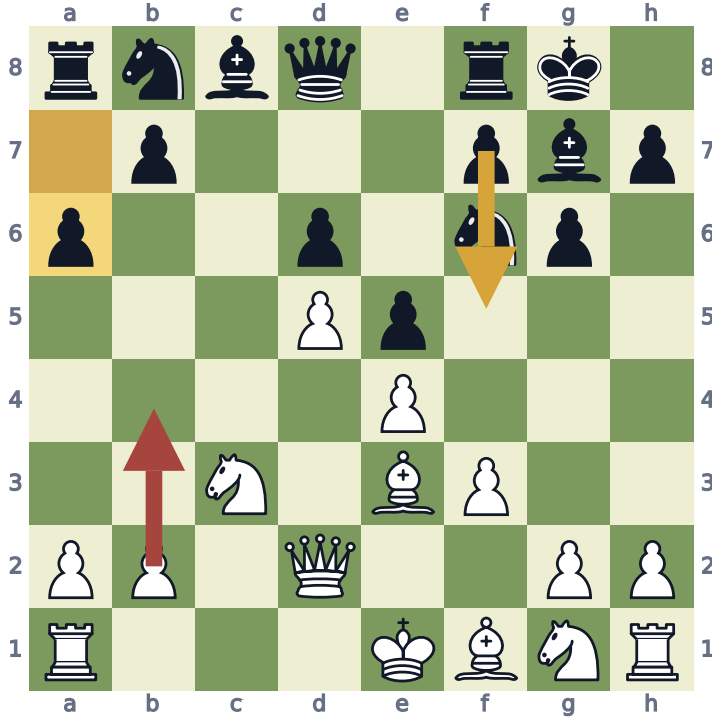
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CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

Pressure the center, prepare ...b5 or ...Nh5, and watch the king's destination.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack.

FAILURE MODE

Attacking the queenside automatically can open lines toward your own targets after opposite-side castling.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

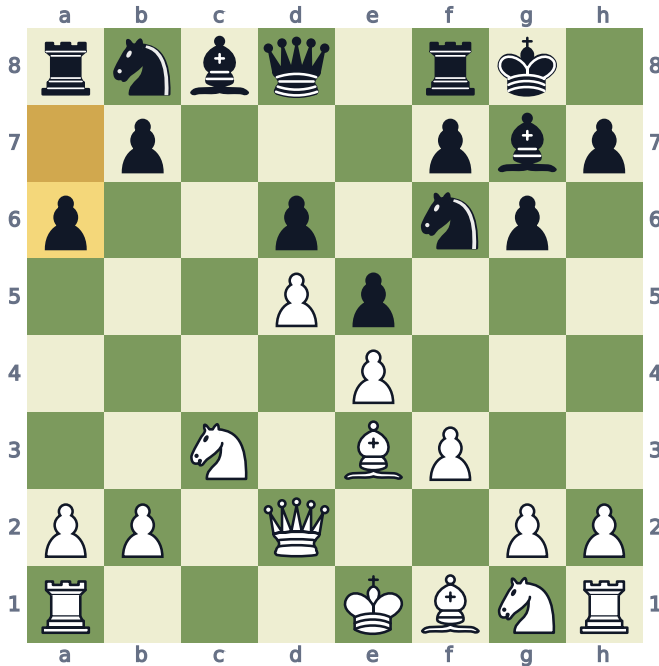
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 e5 7. d5 c6 8. Qd2 cxd5 9. cxd5 a6



- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- cxd5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- cxd5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king. White's resistance is: White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack. The line fails as a template when: Attacking the queenside automatically can open lines toward your own targets after opposite-side castling.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

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ANSWER KEY

1. Black challenges the broad center while White's f3 setup supports e4 and prepares queenside castling. 2. Pressure the center, prepare ...b5 or ...Nh5, and watch the king's destination. 3. White seeks Qd2, long castling, g4, and a direct attack. 4. Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king. 5. Attacking the queenside automatically can open lines toward your own targets after opposite-side castling.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. d5 c6 8. Qd2 cxd5 9. cxd5 a6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The g4 space grab

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

White uses g4-g5 to restrict f6 and claim kingside space before castling.

DECISION RULE

Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Challenge the base, find squares for the knight, and counter in the center or queenside.

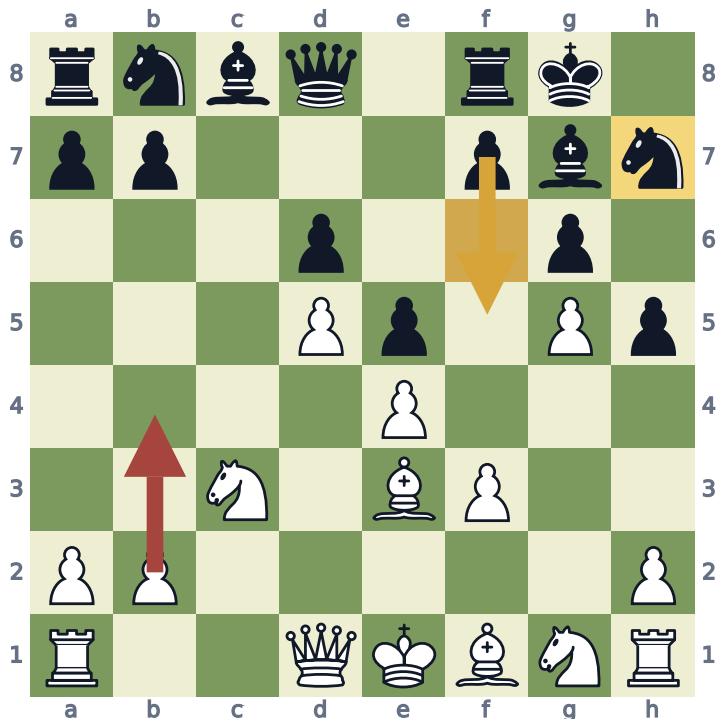
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may follow with h4 and long castling, but the advanced pawns can become targets.

MEMORY RULE | A restraining pawn move must also create a route for the restricted piece.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White may follow with h4 and long castling, but the advanced pawns can become targets.

FAILURE MODE

Closing the kingside can help White if Black has no counterplay elsewhere.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

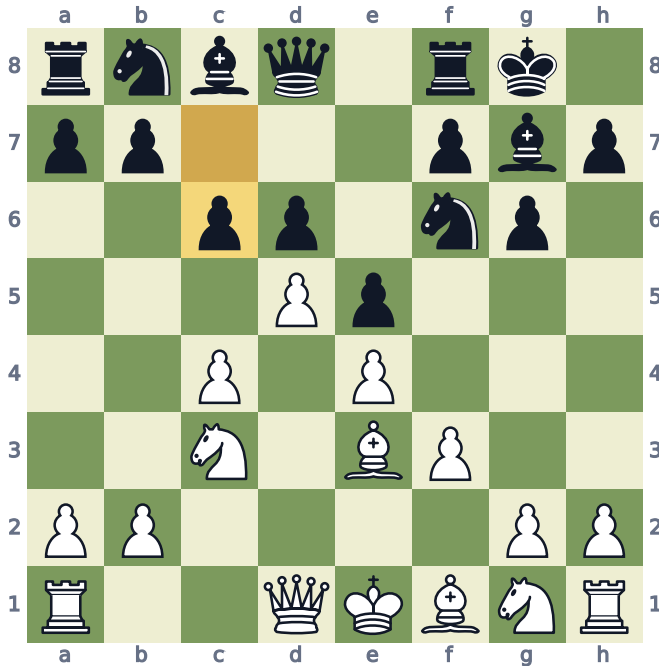
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Move-by-move meaning

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- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

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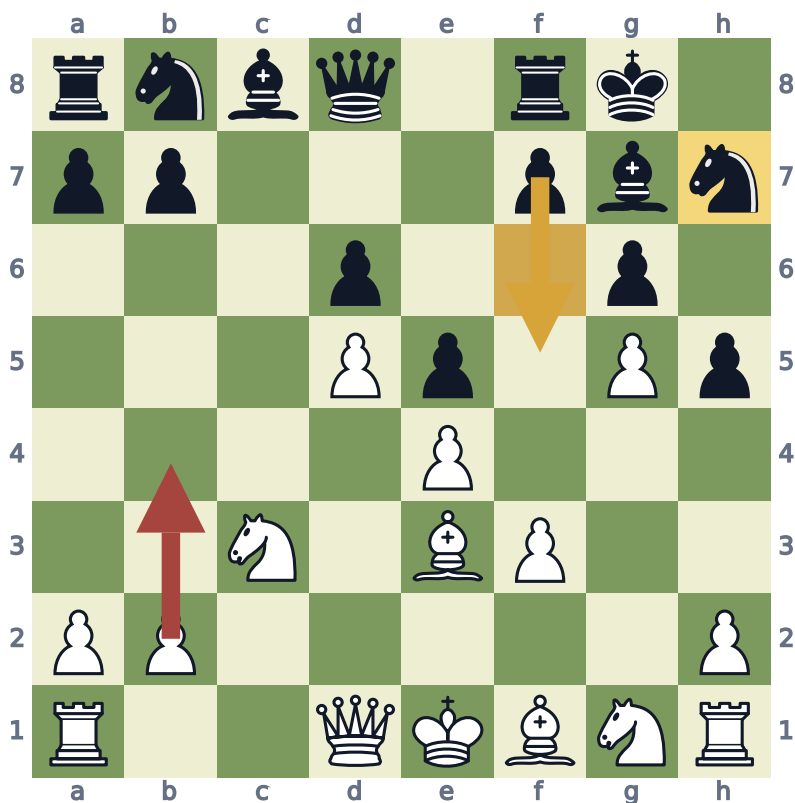
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 e5 7. d5 c6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The g4 space grab

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

White uses g4-g5 to restrict f6 and claim kingside space before castling.

DECISION RULE

Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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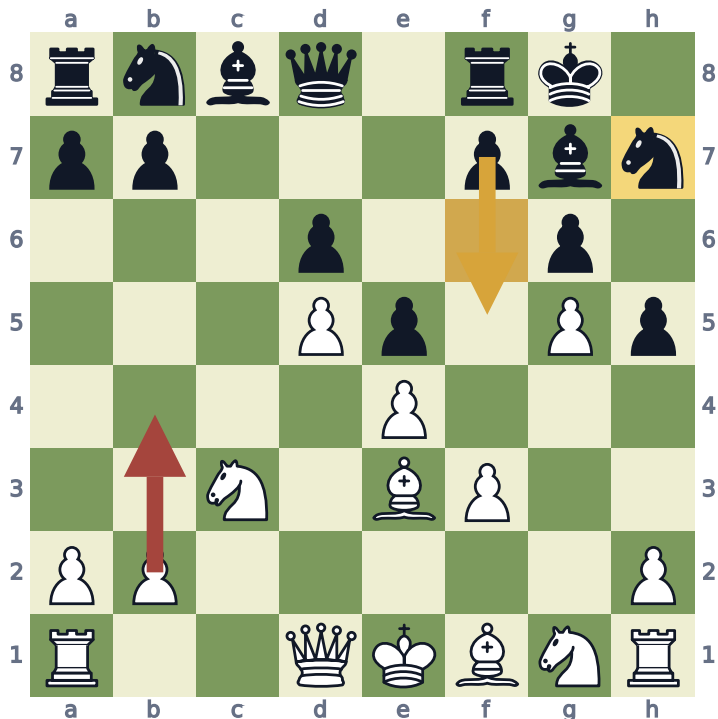
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

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Closing the kingside can help White if Black has no counterplay elsewhere.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

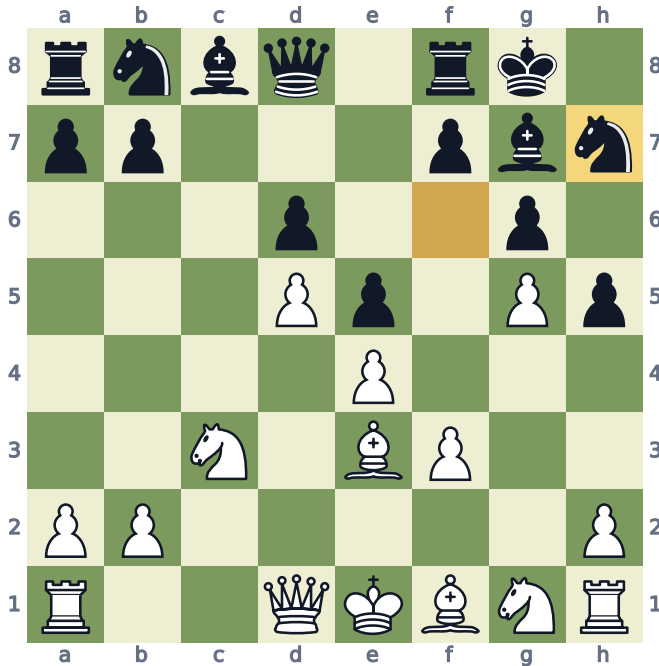
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Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- g4: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- cxd5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- cxd5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- h5: Black gains or fixes kingside space and prepares line-opening contact for the pieces.
- g5: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nh7: Black reroutes a knight toward h7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook. White's resistance is: White may follow with h4 and long castling, but the advanced pawns can become targets. The line fails as a template when: Closing the kingside can help White if Black has no counterplay elsewhere.

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Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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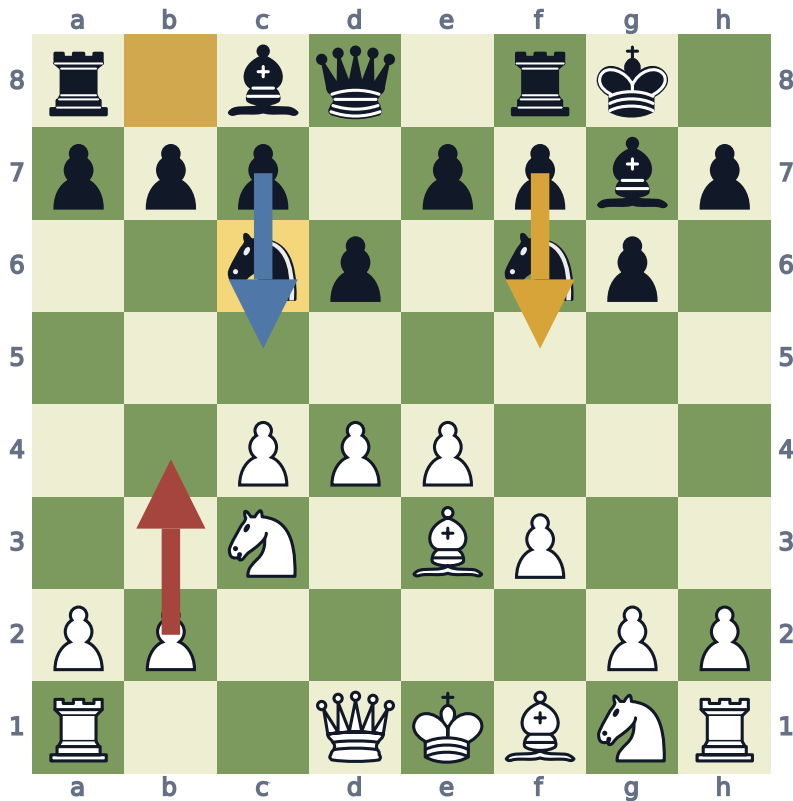
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. g4 cxd5 9. cxd5 h5 10. g5 Nh7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Panno knight route



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Panno setup provokes central expansion and then attacks it with ...c6 while keeping ...e5 available.

DECISION RULE

Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use the knight's retreat to support c5, e5, or b6 and avoid trapping it.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains space with d5 and f4 and may advance e5.

MEMORY RULE | A retreat earns its tempo by making the opponent's center less stable.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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FAILURE MODE

Provoking pawns is only useful if the resulting targets can be attacked.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

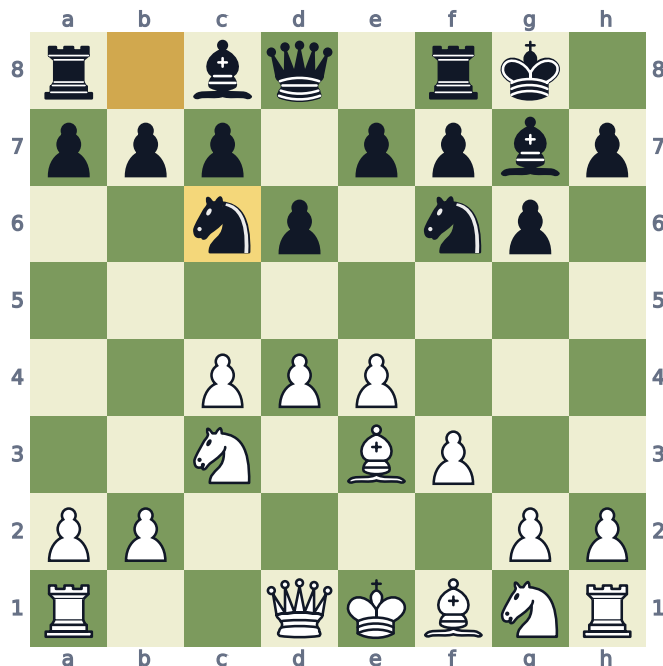
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 Nc6 7. d5 Ne5 8. f4 Ned7 9. Nf3 c6



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight toward c6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

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ANSWER KEY

1. The Panno setup provokes central expansion and then attacks it with ...c6 while keeping ...e5 available. 2. Use the knight's retreat to support c5, e5, or b6 and avoid trapping it. 3. White gains space with d5 and f4 and may advance e5. 4. Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up. 5. Provoking pawns is only useful if the resulting targets can be attacked.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 Nc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Panno knight route



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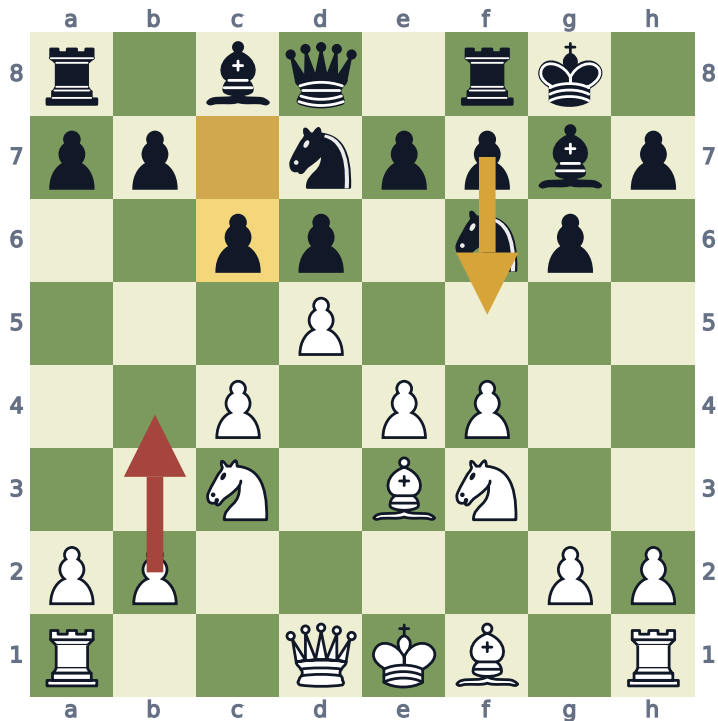
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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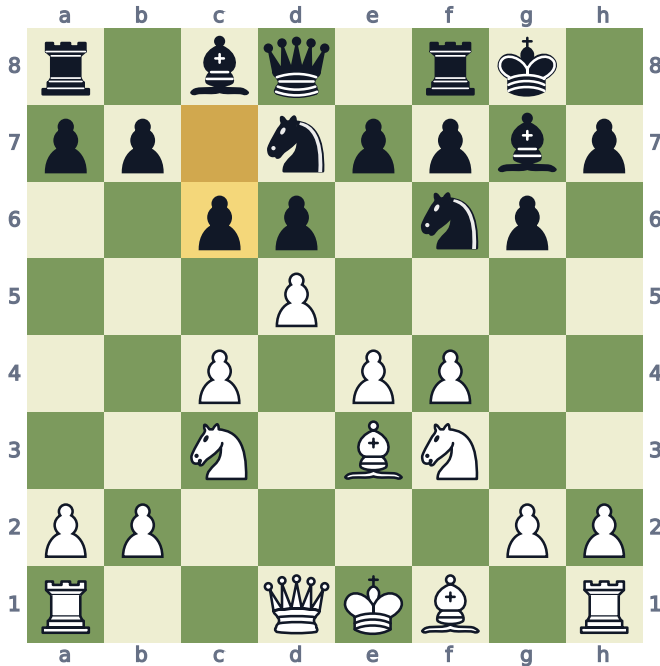
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Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 Nc6 7. d5 Ne5 8. f4 Ned7 9. Nf3 c6



- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ne5: Black reroutes a knight toward e5; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- f4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Ned7: Black reroutes a knight toward d7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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ANSWER KEY

1. The Panno setup provokes central expansion and then attacks it with ...c6 while keeping ...e5 available. 2. Use the knight's retreat to support c5, e5, or b6 and avoid trapping it. 3. White gains space with d5 and f4 and may advance e5. 4. Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up. 5. Provoking pawns is only useful if the resulting targets can be attacked.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. d5 Ne5 8. f4 Ned7 9. Nf3 c6

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 037 Decode: The e5 and c6 structure

Prompt: Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king.

Recall: In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

LESSON 038 Play: The e5 and c6 structure

Prompt: Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king.

Recall: In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

LESSON 039 Decode: The g4 space grab

Prompt: Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook.

Recall: A restraining pawn move must also create a route for the restricted piece.

LESSON 040 Play: The g4 space grab

Prompt: Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook.

Recall: A restraining pawn move must also create a route for the restricted piece.

LESSON 041 Decode: The Panno knight route

Prompt: Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up.

Recall: A retreat earns its tempo by making the opponent's center less stable.

LESSON 042 Play: The Panno knight route

Prompt: Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up.

Recall: A retreat earns its tempo by making the opponent's center less stable.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The e5 and c6 structure

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 e5 7. d5 c6 8. Qd2 cxd5 9. cxd5 a6

Decision: Choose the wing of counterplay only after White reveals the king.

Memory: In the Saemisch, king location determines the meaning of every pawn break.

CARD 2

The g4 space grab

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 e5 7. d5 c6 8. g4 cxd5 9. cxd5 h5 10. g5 Nh7

Decision: Decide whether ...h5 creates a useful lock or gives White a hook.

Memory: A restraining pawn move must also create a route for the restricted piece.

CARD 3

The Panno knight route

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f3 O-O 6. Be3 Nc6 7. d5 Ne5 8. f4 Ned7 9. Nf3 c6

Decision: Treat the retreat square as part of the plan, not as a concession made without a follow-up.

Memory: A retreat earns its tempo by making the opponent's center less stable.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
037 Decode: The e5 and c6 structure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
038 Play: The e5 and c6 structure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
039 Decode: The g4 space grab	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
040 Play: The g4 space grab	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
041 Decode: The Panno knight route	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
042 Play: The Panno knight route	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.